meal, made an exception for us. We could have whatever we wanted. And that's how it ended – the 704 wickets, the 188 Test matches, the 170 registered injuries, the endless feuds with all those grizzled cricketers – sitting with Joe, eating hot wings, shielding our eyes as the sun came up.

There were 330 pints drunk that day in the England dressing room. I can remember my first, sitting next to Nasser Hussain as soon as that first Test was won. It had all begun in the very same place with him as my captain all those years ago, when I entered to find a room packed full of players I'd only ever seen on television. It ended with Nasser again, this time him holding a microphone, live on Sky Sports, my current teammates gathered around me in silence, waiting on every word. I looked around the room as we went on air and scanned my team, first Ben Stokes to my left, already getting through his first Guinness, then the others, some not even born when Nasser had first picked me. There was probably a total of about 40 years' difference between my first teammates and the ones in here now. I wouldn't dare even try to look it up. But Nasser, in this new capacity, decades thawed out from the man who watched my first over go for 17 runs and then reluctantly apologised for the field he set, sat there now visibly moved, his hands gently trembling as we conducted one last interview. I didn't want to let the cricket go, and somehow found myself telling him, 'I'm still gutted I dropped that catch, to be honest.' It had stuck for a second, in my left hand, like a fairy tale, and then bounced out, like real life.

I can remember my second pint too, walking out on to the balcony to see Lord's scattered with tens of thousands of people, all looking back up at us, waiting for a glimpse. I downed it in one. It was one of the biggest cheers I've ever received. To be fair, it was quick. Still, I can also just about recall when I nearly broke down back in the dressing room, as Ben told the group that the most important thing about me was that I was a good bloke. Joe presents me with a fielding mitt, given the amount of coaching drills I will be doing with them for the remainder of the summer. The rest of that evening, there are holes. I can just about re-find the tenth pint, when a woman flown in from Rome hand-delivered a guitar from Coldplay that had been on stage with them that same evening. It was that kind of day.

I'm having to almost physically force my eyelids open from the haze this morning. There is a text at the top of a long list of unread messages – it